thames view
YOUR COMMUNITY MAGAZINE
ISSUE 10
NOVEMBER 05

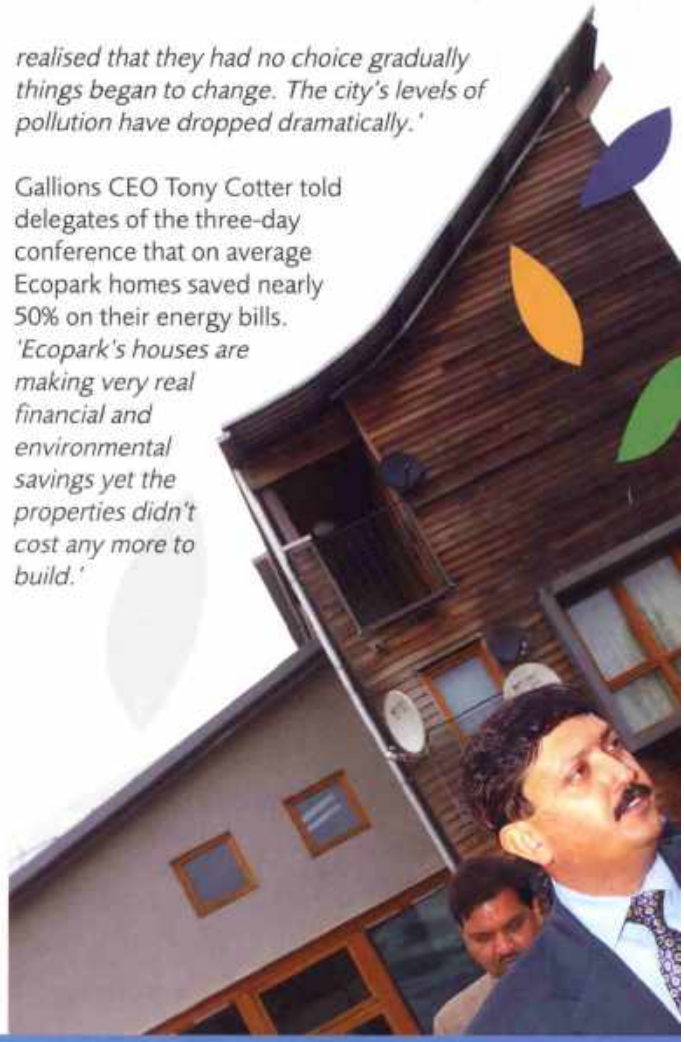
INTERNATIONAL CLIMATE CONFERENCE VISITS ECOPARK IN THAMESMEAD

Gallions' reputation as an environmentally-friendly housing association was given a boost last month as some 40 international visitors took time out from Mayor Ken Livingstone's Climate Summit to visit Ecopark. This development shows how homes can be built using the latest technology to help reduce energy use. The visitors came from many of the world's major cities and were gathered together in London to talk about how best to deal with global warming.

For many of the visitors it was the first time they had seen anything like Ecopark and all were keen to learn lessons to take back to their own country. Shelley Carroll, a councilor in the City of Toronto was particularly impressed with Ecopark's use of a sunspace. It make the rooms seem larger and is an ideal way to cut down on heating costs. Mrs Carroll said: *'In Toronto we need to push harder to make real environmental changes in the housing sector. The big cities must lead the way and we will see the results trickling down to smaller communities.'*

Climate change is topping governments' agendas around the world with each country takiing a different approach. Mr Sudhir Mahajan, Secretary to the Minister of the Environment in New Delhi explained how his government forced through new laws. *'The entire public transport system in New Delhi is now run on compressed natural gas. It wasn't easy but as people realised that they had no choice gradually things began to change. The city's levels of pollution have dropped dramatically.'*

Gallions CEO Tony Cotter told delegates of the three-day conference that on average Ecopark homes saved nearly 50% on their energy bills. *'Ecopark's houses are making very real financial and environmental savings yet the properties didn't cost any more to build.'*



NEWS REVIEW
Tax credits in focus

SAFETY FIRST
Essential gas checks

ONE TO ONE
Building Bridges

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

Most delegates said that that was the key message they would be taking back to their own countries. In keeping with the subject of climate change, visitors were driven to and from Ecopark in a bus powered by a hydrogen fuel cell, one of only three such vehicles in the country.



A 'HANDS ON' APPROACH

Ecopark is just one example of how Gallions helps promote protecting the planet. Team Gallions was established as a specialist environmental team to ensure the Thamesmead neighbourhood was kept as clean, safe and attractive as possible. Today their role goes beyond that with their environmental message being taken into a number of schools and youth clubs.

Many of Gallions' community projects have reflected their commitment to environmental issues. Young people are encouraged to take part in river clean up operations and gardening projects. The benefits of recycling are promoted; bird boxes have been installed to encourage more wildlife to Southmere Lake. As experts around the world call for extreme measures to halt the crisis of climate change, Gallions continues to take small but significant steps in helping to teach young people that they must take more care of their environment.

One such project was when a group of school children from Bexley Business Academy decided that they wanted to do some environmental work. They were invited to design and build a garden for the elderly residents of a local care home. Most had never gardened before. However, they all enjoyed the work and felt they learnt a lot about plants and wildlife. It is this 'hands on' approach to the environment that Gallions is encouraging.



If you know of any environmental projects that are going on in your school or neighbourhood, please get in touch with the Thamesview team. Tel: 0208 320 3414 or email: thamesview@gallionsha.co.uk

CLEANING UP

More rubbish is thrown out on the streets over the festive season than at any other time. Many residents are angry that when their family visits, the area looks dirty and untidy. Team Gallions spend an enormous amount of time and money trying to keep Thamesmead tidy.

DETAILS OF WHEN, WHERE AND HOW YOU CAN GET RID OF YOUR RUBBISH CORRECTLY WILL BE SENT TO YOU AT THE BEGINNING OF DECEMBER. LET'S MAKE THIS CHRISTMAS REALLY SPARKLE.

ISSUE #10
editorial

A recent report highlighted the threat our world faces when it outlined a whole range of wildlife and flowers that are in danger of disappearing. Entitled, '100 things your grandchildren may never see', it makes a depressing list.

Swallow
The loss of such a common bird shows that there is a very major crisis.

Tiger
The wild tiger will probably disappear from South East Asia in the next 10 years.

Turtle Dove
Fewer birds are arriving in Britain and fewer are breeding due to a lack of food.

Deptford Pink
This flower grows on dry banks and borders and is a victim of fertiliser and pollution.

Marsh Fritillary butterfly
With five British species already extinct this variety is next in line to disappear.

Snow
With temperatures growing steadily it is likely that by 2050 there will be no snow anywhere in Britain.

Coral Reefs
Coastal development and global warming are threatening reefs that have been around for thousands of year.

This year experts are saying that it may be one of harshest winters in over 40 years. There is talk about power cuts, soaring fuel prices and massive disruption to transport across the country. For the elderly, winter is always a difficult time. However, if the forecasts are true, this winter could prove deadly. Gallions Wardens will be visiting and checking up on the elderly as usual throughout the winter months. For those without family nearby, their visits will become more important than ever. If severe weather does strike remember that your elderly neighbours may be struggling to keep warm.

4 **News review**
Benefits help and advice

5 **Community round up**
Wates, wardens and local heroes

6 **Winter notes**
Keep active this winter

8 **Safety first**
Keep that gas appointment

9 **One to One**
Building Bridges

10 **Coming soon**
New year, new skills

11 **The project office**
What's going on at no.12

ਜੇ ਅੰਗਰੇਜ਼ੀ ਤੁਹਾਡੀ ਪਹਿਲੀ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਨਹੀਂ, ਅਤੇ ਤੁਸੀਂ ਇਸ ਦਸਤਾਵੇਜ਼ ਦਾ ਤਰਜਮਾ ਚਾਹੁੰਦੇ ਹੋ, ਤਾਂ ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ ਆਪਣੀ ਚੁਣੀ ਹੋਈ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਦੇ ਨਾ ਦੇ ਨੇੜੇ ਵਾਲੇ ਖ਼ਾਨੇ ਵਿਚ ਸਹੀ ਦਾ ਨਿਸ਼ਾਨ ਲਾ ਕੇ, ਅਤੇ ਦੱਸੀ ਹੋਈ ਥਾਂ 'ਤੇ ਆਪਣਾ ਨਾਂ ਅਤੇ ਪਤਾ ਲਿਖ ਕੇ ਇਹ ਫ਼ਾਰਮ ਕਿਸੇ ਲਿਫ਼ਾਫ਼ੇ ਵਿਚ ਪਾ ਕੇ ਹੇਠ ਲਿਖੇ ਪਤੇ 'ਤੇ ਭੇਜ ਦਿਓ।

如果英語不是您的母語，您希望將該文件翻譯出來的話，請在您選擇的語言旁邊打勾，請在所示之處填上您的姓名和地址，併用信封將本表格寄到下列地址。

Nếu Anh ngữ không phải là ngôn ngữ chính, Quý vị muốn dịch tài liệu này, xin vui lòng đánh dấu vào ô kế bên ngôn ngữ Quý vị chọn, ghi tên và địa chỉ vào nơi chỉ dẫn và gởi mẫu vào phòng bì theo địa chỉ dưới đây.

November 05

PUNJABI ☐ CHINESE ☐ VIETNAMESE ☐

(please tick one)

Name: _____

Address: _____

Return to: Joy McKee, Translation Requests, Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH

News Review

TAX CREDITS THE CHAOS CONTINUES

The September deadline for finalising the 2004/2005 tax credits claims has passed and thousands of people may have missed the deadline. However, Derek Stainsby, Gallions Welfare Benefits Officer, says that there is still time to appeal if you are having problems with tax credits.

The tax credit help lines have been very busy recently and many people are finding it impossible to get through even on the Welfare Rights Advisors lines. Meanwhile the Inland Revenue continues to recover thousands of alleged overpayments before claimants have been able to appeal. Against this background, the re-assuring statements made by ministers and published in their own code of practice are beginning to look a bit weak.

Unlike other social security benefit overpayments, tax credit overpayments are legally recoverable whatever their cause. Housing benefit and council tax benefit overpayments are not recoverable if they were caused by official error and the claimant or payee could not reasonably be expected to realise they were being overpaid. While it is not possible to appeal against decisions to recover tax credit overpayments, it is possible to challenge that there has been an overpayment in the first place.

I have managed to get a number of overpayments 'remitted' by showing that the overpayment was a mistake by the revenue or that the claimant did not know they were being overpaid. If you are having problems with tax credits please contact Gallions on 0800 838481 for an appointment with your Welfare Benefits Officer.

A WORD OF WARNING



School children with mobile phones, iPods and MP3 players are becoming the favourite targets of young street thieves in Bexley, and the local Community Safety Partnership is appealing to children to leave them at home. The following steps can be taken to help with the recovery and return of stolen goods.

Mark the items with postcodes and house numbers using an ultraviolet pen Register them with MEND at www.menduk.org or www.immobilise.uk Keep a separate note of the unique IMEI number, which can be found on phones by keying in *#06#

Report offences as soon as possible
For more information about Bexley Community Safety Partnership please ring 0800 389 5013 or go to www.bexley.gov.uk/communitysafety

Also, elderly residents are being advised to be careful who they open their doors to at night. If you are unsure about who is calling then do not open the door and do not invite anyone in that you do not know. Remember, most firms with legitimate business will not be calling on elderly residents when it is dark.

Community Roundup

Feathering their nest

As part of a Wates community day that was marked in various sites around the country, the construction firm arranged for the Royal Society for the Protection of Birds to install more bird nesting boxes around Southmere Lake. Keith Noble from the RSPB was amazed at the variety of wildlife already in and around the lake. On his visit he spotted herons, grey wagtails, chaffinch, tufted ducks a great spotted woodpecker and starlings. With the boxes safely installed Keith is confident that more wildlife will be attracted to the area.



LOCAL HEROES

This year's GRB Housing Fair saw the launch of Gallions 'Pride in Thamesmead' Award. Four long-standing Thamesmead residents were recognised for their contribution to the community. Alison Breese, Director of Operations presented Jim Flynn, Ken Sealey and Ted Claridge with a specially designed sculpture to mark the occasion. Don Williams, the former editor and publisher of the much-respected Thamesmead People, was presented with his award at a later date. Don has worked tirelessly for the local community and his newspaper was as essential part of Thamesmead life. Poor health forced Don to retire over a year ago – his newspaper is still very much missed today.



Wardens come top of the class

Gallions Neighbourhood Wardens have joined forces with Heronsgate School to discuss ways in which they can work together to stop youngsters becoming involved in anti-social behaviour. The wardens have visited the school to introduce themselves to the children and to tell them about the work they do in the community. They will be spending time with the children at lunchtime and after school and plans are in the pipeline to introduce a Junior Warden scheme that will encourage young people to become more involved in community projects. Headteacher Mr Proctor is looking forward to seeing some good results for the whole Broadwaters area coming from the partnership between the wardens and his school.



Winter Notes

The clocks have changed and the dark winter evenings are getting longer. For many people it is a time to stay indoors in front of the television. If this is your idea of winter, then think again. Gallions has put together programme of events designed to make the winter nights pass more quickly. Don't despair because even if is dark and cold, there is something to do for the young and the elderly in Thamesmead.

GONE FISHING

Gallions fishing club continues to go from strength to strength with numbers regularly reaching nearly 20. Less energetic than the street league but equally as popular the club has now moved to Saturday afternoons between 1pm and 5pm. The venue remains the same, behind Thamesmere Leisure Centre. Phil Briggs, the Neighbourhood Warden who runs it is delighted with the turn out. "The club is open to anyone above the age of 8 years old. We supply the equipment and the training. Once you have caught your first fish, you are hooked!"

GETTING OUT AND ABOUT

Gallions has recently joined Bexley's Accessible Transport scheme. This means they now have a trained minibus driver on hand as well as the opportunity to hire a minibus at a reduced rate. Kathy Keane, Gallions Older Persons Co-ordinator is delighted with the scheme and has already made plans to take some of the elderly on trips throughout the winter. Kathly says: "Winter is always a difficult time for the elderly and the Accessible Transport scheme makes it possible for us to arrange outings and events for them. We will be sending out more details of our trips over the next few weeks." As always, the Neighbourhood Wardens will be out and about visiting older residents. While the wardens play an important role in the community they have come to provide an essential service to the older residents.

MAY THE BEST TEAM WIN

October saw the launch of a fiercely fought competition – the football street league. Six five-a-side teams are pitting their talents against each other in a league set to go right to the wire. Games are played every Monday night at the Ball Court in Wolvercote Road. In a winning idea brought about by a partnership between Gallions, Charlton Athletic FC, Areas of Opportunity, Bexley's Youth Services and the Metropolitan police the league is already supported by many locals. Why not come along on a Monday evening and cheer on your favourite team?

SAFETY FIRST AT FIREWORKS NIGHT

The first few weeks of November will see more fireworks displays and bonfires than at any other time of the year. That's why it is so important to follow a few safety rules to make sure everybody keeps safe.

Never go near a firework that has been lit but has not yet exploded
Always supervise children around fireworks
Never put fireworks in your pocket or throw them

Keep fireworks in a closed box
Light them at arms lengths

Faith in THE PLANET

A Multi-Faith Conference on the Environment
St. Mary Magdalene Church, Woolwich
Sunday 6th November 2005
1.00 - 4.30pm

Hosted by Southwark Diocesan Inter Faith Group and London and Southwark Dioceses Christian Action Re the Environment and supported by Greenwich Multi-Faith Forum and the Anglo Asian African Caribbean Friendship and Cultural Association. This conference is open to anyone interested in promoting interfaith understanding care for the environment. Speakers are from two faith groups and one from a secular environmental groups: Jain Speaker: Dr Batubhai Shah,; Muslim Speaker: Prof. Dawud Niobi, Best Foot Forward Speaker: Mr Steve Piltz).

Lunch provided at 1pm by the Anglo Asian Caribbean Friendship and Cultural Association. Free parking available at the front of the church on Greenlaw Street.

For information about the conference phone: 020 7717 2953.
For information about the location phone: 020 8854 2302.
For travel directions and parking info, consult the church website:
www.parishofwoolwich.org.uk

CELEBRATING DIVERSITY

There are a number of inter-faith meetings and conferences being held in the area throughout the winter months. The 'Faith in the Planet' conference on the environment takes place in Woolwich on 6th November while 3rd December is the start of two-week programme to celebrate multi-faith groups within Thamesmead.

EADIP CELEBRATES UNITY WITHIN OUR MULTI FAITH COMMUNITY

Saturday 3rd December
Launches 2 weeks of activities giving
An opportunity to celebrate and inform contributions
From multi faith groups with Thamesmead.

The launch will take place on

Saturday 3rd Dec 2-4pm

There will be a main keynote information talk at 2.15pm.
During the FREE launch there will be music from around the world, henna hand painting and members from various faiths available to talk about activities within the local community.
Snacks from around the world will also be available.
This will take place in the Jubliee Room, Tenants resource Centre at Gallions Housing Association.

Between Mon 5th-fri 16th there will be a display at reception celebrating and helping to develop our understanding multi-faith within our community.

For more information please contact Wendy Mason, Resident Involvement Officer on 0800 83 84 81.

Talking Heads

Gallions is putting together a panel to discuss all apsects of their resident communication. They need 10 adults (over 18) to discuss what works, what doesn't and what could work better. If you are free during the day of the first week of December and would like to contribute to this communications panel, please contact Caroline Wilson no later than 14th November on 0208 320 3409. Panel members will be selected and notified by the end of Novermber and each will receive £50 a day to cover expenses.

GET IT CHECKED

Carbon monoxide is a poisonous gas that you cannot smell or see. Every year around 30 people across the country die as a result of carbon monoxide poisoning. Gallions has a legal responsibility to inspect their tenants gas boilers and gas heaters every year. Most residents are happy for gas engineers to carry out this essential safety check. However some tenants are refusing entry to these engineers. When this happens, Gallions has no option but to seek a Court injunction to force those tenants to let the engineers carry out their safety checks.

Two tenants were recently taken to Woolwich County Court and the judge decided that they should pay Court costs of £640 each because they failed to keep their appointments. **The only way to prevent Court action and costs of over £600 is to make a gas safety appointment and keep it.** If you know that your boiler has not been inspected in the last 12 months, please contact the Customer Contact Team on 0800 838481 as soon as possible. It is only a 30 minute check and it could save your life.



LEASEHOLDERS LINE

Gallions leasehold management team has been put in place to ensure that leaseholders receive a comprehensive, efficient after-sales service. Lead by JanetNorman, the team handles all general leasehold questions as well as queries about:

SHARED OWNERSHIP RENTS
SERVICE CHARGES
CHANGE OF OWNERSHIP
STAIRCASING
REMORTGAGING
RIGHT TO BUY/ACQUIRE

A morning surgery for leaseholders is held between 10am and 12pm on the first Thursday of every month in Gallions Tenants Resource Centre, Harrow Manor Way. Please contact Hazel Church on 0208 320 3415 to make an appointment.

LEASEHOLDERS SURGERY
THURSDAY 3RD NOVEMBER 10AM –12PM
THURSDAY 1ST DECEMBER 10AM-12PM

THANK U

As part of an on-going review of their services, Gallions would like to thank everyone who completed and returned their recent questionnaire. The following four residents received gift vouchers.

Mr Omene * Mr Drostle
Mr Bradford * Mr Umunna

Ms Leask was the winner of Gallions efficiency prize with her suggestion to check the timers on lights to make sure they are not left on at night. Your opinions help Gallions deliver a service that meets the needs of the community. If you have something to say why not contact the Gallions Resident Involvement Team on getinvolved@gallionsha.co.uk

one to one

BUILDING BRIDGES AT NUMBER 23



Thamesmead East has one of the highest rates of teenage pregnancies in Bexley and Britain has the highest in Europe. While the statistics are not good, there is a growing determination to address the problem and tackle the issues head on. One group of workers in Thamesmead is launching a project that will target every aspect of the teenage pregnancy issue. Lorraine Webster, a senior support worker for Bexley Youth Engagement Services, is a member of the group and tells us what makes this project different.

Bexley Care Trust and Bexley Council have long recognised the problems teenage pregnancies can bring. Often young mothers drop out of education and many are living in poverty by the time they reach their early thirties. Working with Gallions, these two organisations are the driving force behind a youth advisory clinic to be based at number 23 Tavy Bridge.

The project is aimed at all young people up to the age of 19 and offers three core services – sexual health advice and counseling; a support network for teenage mothers; counseling and advice to teenage fathers. Lorraine says:

'The clinic at number 23 is not a youth community facility but an advice centre with trained counselors and health professionals on hand to deal with all areas of teenage pregnancies. The services we offer look at the complete picture. We hope this approach may help provide a more comprehensive solution to the issues of teenage pregnancies.'

The idea for the advice centre started when the group realised that while there were a number of highly successful groups for teenage mothers, there was no support network for teenage fathers. Initial research showed that young dads were experiencing a whole range of different problems and many would welcome some help and advice. Time and time again Lorraine has seen how young fathers simply don't know what is expected of them when the baby arrives.

'Often the parents' relationship has broken down completely leaving the father with no access to his child. We want to maximise the opportunities for teenage dads to develop positive and enduring relationships with their children.'

Gallions Housing Association has donated number 23 Tavy Bridge to the project. The sexual health clinic will be run as a drop in centre where no appointment is necessary. These clinics will offer a confidential service where young people can seek advice on contraception, pregnancy or termination. Young mothers *and* fathers can learn parenting skills or seek advice about issues ranging from maintenance to maintaining contact. Lorraine is confident that this multi-layered approach to teenage pregnancies will have a positive impact for all involved. To find out more about the Bridge project call Linda Nash on 0208 320 3451.

WHAT'S COMING UP

LEARN SOMETHING NEW FOR THE NEW YEAR

Bexley's Adult Education Neighbourhood learning programme is running a wide variety of free courses and training over the winter months. All courses are based in the Adult Education Southlake Centre, Seacourt Road, Thamesmead. Please call Jas on 01322 552561 or Sharon on 0208 311 8165 for more information.

COURSE	TIME	DATE
Food Hygiene	10am - 12pm	Wednesday 9/11/05
Hairstyling	1pm - 3pm	Tuesday 8/11/05
Office Skills (beginners	10am - 12pm	Monday 7/11/05
Job Search Skills & Interview techniques Workshops	1pm - 3pm	Wednesday 2/11/05

Don't just play, COACH

If it has always been your goal to become a football coach then now is your chance. Bexley's Adult Education College and Charlton Athletic have teamed up to offer a free level 1 football coaching course starting in November 2005. The course is the first step in a series of certificates that will allow you to assist a qualified football coach. For more information or to book a place on the course please contact Jas on 01322 552561.

FA LEVEL 1 ADULT (16+) FOOTBALL COACHING COURSES

VENUE: Charlton Athletic Training Ground, Sparrows Lane, New Eltham

Saturday 26th November	9am - 5pm	First Aid/Practical
Saturday 3rd December	9am - 5pm	Child Protection/Practical
Saturday 10th December	9am - 5pm	Practical/Theory





What's happening at No.12 Tavy Bridge

Building Futures
Trust Thamesmead has introduced their Training and Employment programme to Tavy Bridge.
Tuesday 10am to 4pm

The Change Project
Benefits and Banking advice to help you understand the changes to benefit payments.
2nd Wednesday of each month. 10am to 4pm

Tavy Bridge Regeneration
Project updates, information and support for everyone involved in the regeneration.
Thursday 10am to 4pm

Neighbourhood Wardens session
Come along and meet Gallions wardens. Find out what plans and projects are in the pipeline.
Thursday 3.30pm to 5pm

Housing Co-ordinators sessions
Thursday 3.30pm 5pm

Thamesmead Law Centre
A trained welfare rights advisor from the Law Centre will be holding weekly sessions at Tavy Bridge.
Tuesday 1pm to3.30pm

0208 320 3568

A DAY IN THE LIFE OF.....

There are 18 members in Gallions Customers Contact Team and every single one of them will tell you that no day is the same. Thamesview caught up with Michael Kortisas and found out that there is no such thing as a typical day in the call centre.

Logging on to the telephone system at 8 am, Michael's first call comes in immediately. It is a straightforward query about repairing guttering and is quickly resolved. By nine o'clock Michael has handled a number of calls with subjects ranging from rubbish collection and rent arrears to cancelled appointments and tree surgery. Variety is clearly the spice of life in the customer contact team. After quite a slow morning the pace has picked up with calls now coming in to Michael every 2 minutes. Just listening to Michael it's clear that he is a mine of information and has an answer for every caller. When Michael hears that four empty properties have been vandalised he acts quickly to ensure the properties are boarded up and safe. The pace is undoubtedly fast and furious and in just one day Michael has taken around 50 calls. Logging off at 4pm Michael reflects on another, hectic, but interesting day at the office.

The busiest times at the call centre are between 8.30 and 10.30 in the morning and again between 12 and 2pm. Your call may be held in a queue if you call at these peak times.







5TH NOVEMBER
FIREWORKS DISPLAY

SOUTHMERE PARK 7.30PM
THAMESMEAD

A free community event for all the family.

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

TRUST. THAMESMEAD

L&Q HOUSING TRUST

Contact us

Gallions Housing Association
Harrow Manor Way
London
SE2 9XH

For all enquiries please contact the
Customer Response Centre
0800 83 84 81
It's a freephone number that you can use to book services, repairs or for any other enquiries.

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION